

## PRODUCT CASE STUDY

# Predictive Driver Availability

*Turning “No Drivers Available” into Recoverable Bookings*

Predicting if a driver will be free, soon enough for a rider to wait and book it

*Author: Koustubh Gadekar*

# Executive Summary

## ➡ Problem

Riders abandon at “No drivers available” since most platforms treat driver supply as binary

Current experience

a driver is either available right now

or the platform shows nothing at all

## ➡ Insight

The backend already predicts near-term driver availability, but the UI reduces this to a yes/no state.

## ➡ Proposal

Predictive Driver Availability: show near-term forecasts (Smart Wait), silently expand search, or offer Notify Me based on model confidence.

### Smart Wait

Show “driver expected  
in ~3 min” — rider chooses

### Expanded Search

Silently widen radius before  
declaring “no drivers”

### Notify Me

Rider can leave the app;  
booking stays alive, not lost

# Problem & User Research

## Observed pain

Most riders abandon the booking immediately after seeing "No drivers available."

Failed bookings lead to missed flights, delays, and safety concerns.

Repeated failures drive complaints and stains the brand trust.

## Behavior signals

Uber's "Wait & Save" showed riders are willing to wait when they know the wait time.

Rejected riders often switch to another app and retry there.

This pattern repeats across cities and peak hours.



### No driver available

We couldn't find any drivers near you right now.



Try again in a few minutes or explore other options.



Try Again



Schedule a Ride

# Root Cause Analysis

- 1 Riders see “no drivers available”
- 2 Matching only checks drivers available right now
- 3 The product asks “is there a driver right now”, not “will there be soon”
- 4 Prediction infrastructure exists internally but isn't surfaced to riders

## ROOT CAUSE

*“Availability is continuous.  
many drivers become  
available within minutes  
as trips end.”*

# Competitor Analysis & Market Gap

| Platform                                                                                                                          | Predicts near-term availability?                                                                                                                          | Search expansion                                                                                                                                                   | Notify me                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Uber</b>                                     |  <b>Partial</b><br>Forecasts exist internally but not shown to riders.   |  <b>Yes</b><br>Uses surge/price adjustment.                                       |  <b>Yes (Limited)</b><br>"Notify me when a driver becomes available" in some cases. |
|  <b>Lyft</b><br>(USA, Canada)                    |  <b>No</b><br>No public indication of near-term availability prediction. |  <b>Limited</b><br>Offers wait for a lower price in some markets.                 |  <b>No</b><br>No equivalent "notify me" option.                                     |
|  <b>Ola / Rapido</b><br>(India)                  |  <b>No</b><br>No public indication of near-term availability prediction. |  <b>Not clearly offered</b><br>No clear communication of expanded search options. |  <b>No</b><br>No "notify me" option after rejection.                                |
|  <b>Grab</b><br>(Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia) |  <b>No</b><br>No public indication of near-term availability prediction. |  <b>Yes</b><br>Shows alternate product types (e.g., GrabCar, GrabBike).           |  <b>Partial</b><br>Offers advance booking reminders, not post-failure "notify me".  |

 Yes – Available

 Partial / Limited

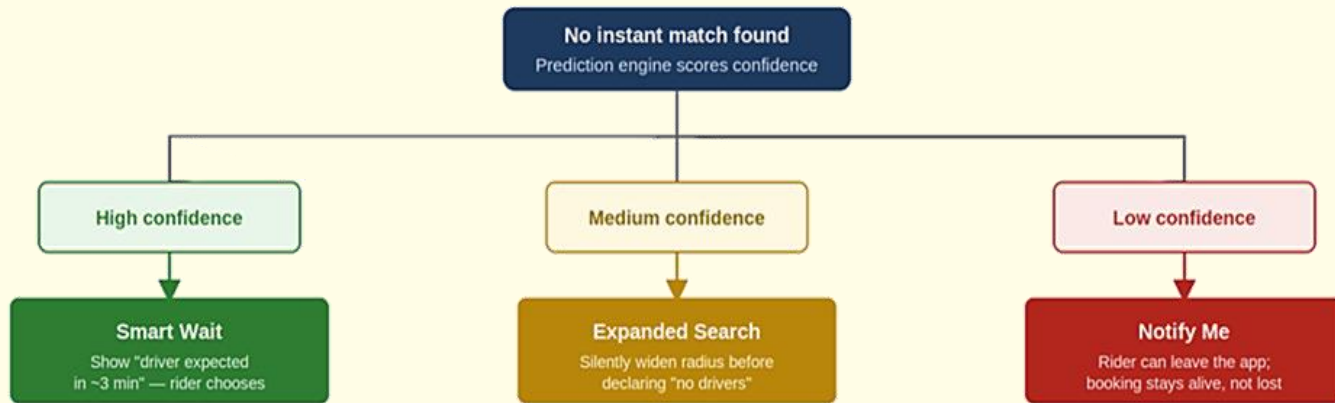
 No – Not available

 Based on publicly available information (May 2025)



Competitors address individual pain points, but not the complete recovery journey. Our solution combines **prediction with multiple recovery paths** to maximize successful bookings.

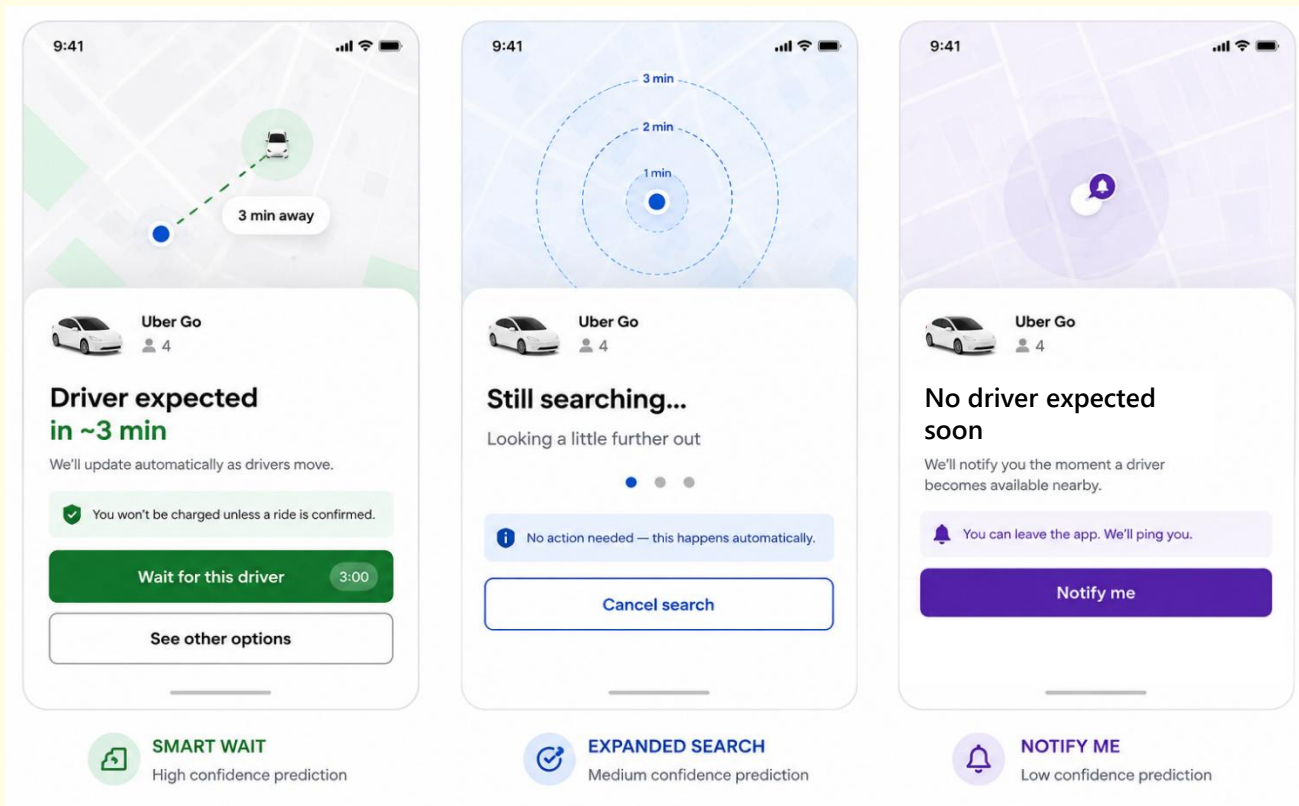
# Solution Overview



Every outcome keeps the booking alive.

Even in the worst case, Notify Me delays abandonment and creates a final opportunity to convert.

# User Experience



# MVP Scope & Success Metrics

## MVP Scope



**Launch City**  
Bengaluru



**Vehicle Category**  
Uber Go only



**Availability Window**  
Peak hours  
(8–11 AM, 6–9 PM)



**Prediction Confidence**  
>90%



**Max Predicted Wait  $\leq 5$  min**

## Success Metrics

**NORTH STAR**

**Ride Completion Rate**

### Primary Metrics:

Booking Conversion

Wait Acceptance

Booking Abandonment

**Guardrail** - False Promise Rate

MVP ships Smart Wait only. Expanded Search and Notify Me are planned fast-follow features.

# Business Impact

*Illustrative assumptions: 8% no-driver rate, 70% abandonment after rejection, 15% recovery, ₹180 average fare, single mid-size city*

Searches

200,000/day

No Drivers

16,000/day

Abandonment

11,200/day

Recovered Rides

1,680/day

Recovered GMV

₹302,400/day

📌 +1,680 rides/day recovered • ₹302K incremental GMV/day • Lower competitor switching

# Risks & Mitigation

1

## Prediction error

**Risk:** Incorrect ETAs reduce user trust.

**Mitigation:** Show predictions only above high-confidence thresholds.

2

## Driver cancellations

**Risk:** Drivers may cancel after prediction.

**Mitigation:** Continuously refresh predictions using live driver signals.

3

## Feature Adoption

**Risk:** Riders may ignore Smart Wait and switch apps anyway.

**Mitigation:** A/B test messaging and different wait times to see what do the riders prefer.

3

# Thank you

Do Check out 😊



[Detailed Case Study](#)



[PRD](#)

After this case study was completed, Rapido introduced a feature that similarly reduces booking abandonment by searching for a better driver in the background when wait times are high. While the problem trigger differs, both solutions share the principle of preserving user intent instead of forcing users to restart the booking flow.